Saudi Arabia: Major Houthi oil strike unlikely

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【メール原文】

Houthis will likely calibrate attacks to avoid an oil-price spike and US intervention, instead mainly focusing on civil and military targets. Risks to||||||||||||||||

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Houthis likely to avoid market-moving strikes on Saudi oil

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What Happened

The Houthis attacked Saudi Aramco’s headquarters in Dhahran on 13 October, causing extensive damage to an administrative building, the latest in a wave of strikes. The military spokesperson of the Yemeni militant group also claimed to have targeted Aramco’s Riyadh refinery and Riyadh airport.

Our Take

The Houthis are unlikely to launch major attacks on Saudi oil to keep the US out of the war. The group judges that a major attack causing an oil price spike could push President Donald Trump to intervene, relieving military pressure on Riyadh. Instead, the Houthis want to deepen tensions between Trump and Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman as Washington avoids direct involvement, despite repeated attacks on Saudi cities, airports, and some energy infrastructure. Fighting Saudi Arabia and the Yemeni government without direct US military intervention gives the Houthis better odds. Their early pledge—communicated to the Trump administration—to spare non-Saudi shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb Strate reflects that calculation, and they have kept to it so far.

Punishing Houthi attacks are, therefore, likely to remain mainly focused on civilian infrastructure such as airports and seaports. Attacks against energy facilities—in some cases in retaliation for strikes on Houthi-controlled energy infrastructure—will likely be calibrated to avoid a price spike.

It is noteworthy that, so far, the Houthis and/or their allies have not conducted an attack of similar caliber to that which knocked out Saudi Arabia’s East-West Pipeline back in September, before Saudi Arabia launched the current offensive.

US intervention or significant battlefield setbacks would sharply increase risks to Saudi oil and Red Sea shipping. Trump continues to resist Saudi requests for direct intervention and is unlikely to authorize operations before the US midterm elections under current battlefield conditions. Riyadh argues that strikes on Houthi missiles and launchers would be largely defensive and protect global energy supplies and shipping.

But US entry into the conflict would weaken the current Houthi incentive to exercise restraint. Saudi-backed advances toward the strategic port of Hodeida or their capital city of Sanaa would also raise the likelihood of major attacks on Saudi oil infrastructure and non-Saudi shipping. However, this scenario has become less likely given the lack of battlefield successes by the Saudi-backed Yemeni government.

Without US intervention, the Saudi-backed Yemeni offensive is heading toward defeat. Last week's coastal offensive has delivered few meaningful gains, and early reports of advances around the Bab el-Mandeb and toward the port of Mocha appear exaggerated. The Houthi encirclement of Taiz threatens another major setback unless reversed.

Turkey and Pakistan are providing military support to the kingdom and Saudi-backed offensive, but relatively limited capabilities and domestic political constraints will likely prevent them from turning the tide. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu may see benefits in intervening to weaken an Iranian ally before his country's elections on 27 October, but direct Israeli involvement would create political difficulties for Riyadh. Mohammed bin Salman reportedly remains skeptical of that option, and any Israeli or US support is for now limited to targeting and intelligence.

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